Buddy Wakefield Collection

By Buddy Wakefield

INTRODUCTION

In an interview in 2012, Buddy Wakefield explained his motivation for writing poetry: "[It's] the reflection. The intention. The idea that someone who had a similar starting point will recognize my writing on the wall as their own, and they will trust it to walk from the bottom of the barrel out."

See, Buddy Wakefield spent a lifetime of overcompensating for a lack of masculinity. He grew up queer in the south and experienced public shame first-hand. And still -- despite his fear of intimacy, he (like we all do) searched for that special someone, and he (like we all have) survived the devastation of a failed major relationship. Gay or straight we all seek connection, we all seek love.

Giant Saint Everything and Hurling Crowbirds at Mockingbars by Buddy Wakefield

Giant Saint Everything

There were days I wanted out.

But then You would go and do things

like dive into the Vancouver ocean,

big brilliant cliché poem that You are,

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water rolling off Your back

as You swam toward a sunset

that hung like a sacred recipe painted

all the way around Your holy head.

And then there were the ways You caught me

moving back into my cave where the wheels turn,

same wheels that drove You off.

I should have told You

before talking in terms of Forever

that any given day wears me out and works me sour,

that there are nights when the sky is so clear

I stand obnoxious underneath it

begging for the stars to shoot at me

just so I can feel at Home.

What's left of You now is a shrine

built from the pieces I kept of Your presence,

Your incredible stretch of presence.

It sits in Our room like a sandpiper

cross-legged and crying,

remembering the night we met

and the day You left, and the Light
shifting in between.
By the side of it stands a picture of the poem where I
promised,
"You will never have another lonely holiday."

The words "I Promise" and "Forever"
begged me not to use them
but sometimes I don't listen to God,
so You can imagine how much it hurt
to let Your last birthday pass
with no word. On August 3rd.
You weren't the only one comin' up lonesome.

Listen, if I had to make a list
of everything everywhere
- and I mean everything… everywhere -
the very last to-do on that infinite list of
every – single – thing – would be – to hurt You,
so I need You to know
that in an attempt to keep my promise
I did write a letter to You on Your birthday.

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It was covered in stickers of flock-printed stars,
choir claps, and a bonfire of buttercups stuck in the air,
but when I finally drew enough courage
to send You all the Love in the World
my hand snapped off in the mailbox
from clenching.

It was returned to me with a gospelstitch, a hope stamp
and a note etched into the palm I had to pry open
with the pressure of pitching doves
reminding me
we agreed to let each other go.

There is a point when tears don't work
to wash things away anymore.
Grabbing for breath has now broken my fingers.
I miss You so much some days
that I beg for the airplane to crash
with just enough time in the freefall
for scribbling "I Love You" across my chest.
That way – when they find my burning breast plate –
they will tell You how the very last thing I did with my

life
was call out Your name.

Arnold Remond Liesting (A.R.L)

I know You're momma didn't raise a sissy,
so it's best if I believe
that You've bounced back and been born again,
but, Baby,

in the bottom left corner of dreams
in the dark spot
where it gets windy and hollow
I can still see you flailing,
eating knuckle cake,
full torque and tender,
heart pounding from being pulled under,
feet bleeding from bracing for endings,
tongue dying to curse Forever
because promises murder us backwards
when people like me don't keep them.

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And sure, we all deserve absolution,
but especially You. You and Faith,
You've got the same hungerpunch, same song
still rising off the watertrain running through the laws
of a moon dead set on daylight
digging marbles from the trees
in a Love not scared to make no sense
and monkey enough to see
the same devastating reason for living this life:
My Giant
Saint
Everything

I promise You.
Forever.

These words have buckled my lips
so far back to the beginning
that I am now allowed only Today,
So today, from my snap-chested heart spraying
fully flying
sending out the birds:

Today I stop believing in words.
Today all my visions reverted blurs
like the night We saw the Light
and I could not shut up

but I swear I was feelin' silence.

HURLING CROWBIRDS AT MOCKINGBARS (HOPE IS NOT A COURSE OF ACTION)

If we were created in God's image
then when God was a child
he smushed fire ants with his fingertips
and avoided tough questions.
There are ways around being the go-to person
even for ourselves
even when the answer is clear
like the holy water Gentiles drank
before they realized Forgiveness
is the release of all hope for a better past.

I thought those were chime shells in your pocket
so I chucked a quarter at it

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hoping to hear some part of you
respond on a high note.
You acted like I was hurling crowbirds at mockingbars
and abandoned me for not making sense.
Evidently, I don't experience things as rationally as you do.

For example, I know mercy
when I have enough money to change the jukebox at a gay bar
(somebody's gotta change that).
You understand the power of God's mercy
whenever someone shoves a stick of morphine
straight up into your heart.
It felt amazing
the days you were happy to see me

so I smashed a beehive against the ocean
to try and make our splash last longer.
Remember all the honey
had me lookin' like a jellyfish ape
but you walked off the water in a porcupine of light

strands of gold
drizzling out to the tips of your wasps.
This is an apology letter to the both of us
for how long it took me to let things go.

It was not my intention to make such a
production of the emptiness between us
playing tuba on the tombstone of a soprano
to try and keep some dead singer's perspective alive.
It's just that I coulda swore you had sung me a love song
back there
and that you meant it
but I guess sometimes people just chew with their
mouth open

so I ate ear plugs alive with my throat
hoping they'd get lodged deep enough inside the empty
spots
that I wouldn't have to hear you leaving
so I wouldn't have to listen to my heart keep saying
all my eggs were in a basket of red flags
all my eyes to a bucket of blindfolds

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in the cupboard with the muzzles and the gauze
ya know I didn't mean to speed so far out and off
trying to drive all your nickels to the well
when you were happy to let them wishes drop

but I still show up for gentleman practice
in the company of lead dancers
hoping their grace will get stuck in my shoes.
Is that a handsome shadow on my breath, sweet woman
or is it a cattle call
in a school of fish? Still dance with me
less like a waltz for panic
more for the way we'd hoped to swing
the night we took off everything
and we were swingin' for the fences

don't hold it against
my love
you know I wanna breath deeper than this
you know I didn't mean to look so serious
didn't mean to act like a filthy floor
didn't mean to turn us both into a cutting board

but there were knives s-stuck
in the words where I came from
too much time in the back of my words.
I pulled knives from my back and my words.
I cut trombones from the moment you slipped away

and I know it left me lookin' like a knife fight, lady
yeah you know it left me feelin' like a shotgun shell
you know I know I mighta gone and lost my breath
but I wanna show ya how I found my breath
to death
it was buried under all the wind instruments
hidden in your castanets
goddamn
if ya ever wanna know how it felt when ya left
yeah if you ever wanna come inside

just knock on the spot

where I finally pressed STOP

playing musical chairs with exit signs.

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I'm gonna cause you a miracle
when you see the way I kept God's image alive.

Forgiveness
is for anybody
who needs a safe passage through my mind.

If I was really created in God's image
then when God was a boy
he wanted to grow up to be a man
a good man
and when God was a man
a good man
He started telling the truth in order to get honest
responses.
He'd say,
"I know.
I really shoulda wore my cross
again
but I don't wanna scare the gentiles off."

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AWARD HISTORY

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